

more wealth and wisdom than him, and in the same breath also maintained that he (Rakesh) was not anybody's clone.

Hounded by regulators, his mentor and close friend Radhakishan Damani took a break from the stock market to set up a supermarket chain under the brand name of D-Mart.

Year 2004 began on a cheery note for the bulls, with the Sensex closing above 6,000 for the first time ever. The success of the Maruti issue encouraged the government to arrange more stake sales through initial and follow-on public offerings. The largest of them was ONGC's follow-on offering in March, which fetched the government around Rs 10,500 crore.

A clerical error at the share registrar's end resulted in HNIs being allotted more shares than they were entitled to. The investors were surprised to see the extra shares when they checked their demat accounts, and many of them immediately sold off their entire lot, hoping to profit from the error.

But pocketing the money was not as easy as they thought it would be. SEBI and the finance ministry swung into action and forced them to return the shares. Being regular traders and well versed with the allotment process, the HNIs could not pretend ignorance.

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As the market continued to climb, retail investors slowly began to test the waters, and brokerages cautiously began adding staff. But the market had one big shock coming in May, which led many to think that the boom was as good as over.

The BJP-led NDA coalition decided to call for elections in April, a good six months ahead of schedule, convinced that the public mood was in its favour. But the move backfired, with the Congress and its allies winning more seats than the NDA coalition. The results came as a dampener for the market, which was rooting for a BJP win as the party was perceived to be pro-business and pro-market. Still, the bulls took it in their stride. But their resilience would be severely tested over the next couple of days.

To block the BJP from forming the government, the Left parties offered to back the Congress-led UPA, but without being part of its government. A day after it promised support, leaders of the Left parties began demanding that the government scrap the divestment policy initiated by the NDA government. That made the market nervous, and it showed its displeasure